

BlueRobins Competitions Page — Verified Candidate List

Compiled: 18 September 2026 **Applies to:** 2026–27 school year (competitions whose cycles run into calendar 2027 are labelled by their own season name) **Status:** Verification pass complete. **No final selections made** — that call is yours.

How this was verified, and the limitation you need to know

Direct page fetching was blocked in this environment: the egress proxy refused `HTTPS CONNECT` to every external host tested (403), so `WebFetch` and `curl` were unusable for all organizer sites. Verification was done instead by **search restricted to each organizer's own domain**, which surfaces organizer-page content without going through round-up blogs.

What that means for you, concretely:

- **URLs in this document are organizer-owned domains that appeared as indexed results** for domain-restricted searches. They were not opened and rendered. Treat them as high-confidence but not click-tested.
- **Facts are drawn from organizer-site content** (rules PDFs, FAQ pages, deadline pages) except where a row explicitly says otherwise. Three rows lean on non-organizer sources and say so.
- Every row carries a confidence note separating *verified* from *inferred* from *not published yet*.
- Where a 2026–27 or 2027 figure genuinely is not yet published as of 18 Sep 2026, the row says so and gives the most recent prior-cycle figure as a **planning proxy, clearly labelled**. Do not put proxy dates on the live page.

A single human pass opening the URLs before publication would close the gap. The rows flagged **LOW CONFIDENCE** should not go live without that pass.

Summary of decisions

Action	Count	Items
Verified and listed	40	numbered entries 1–40 across the three grade bands
Dropped at your instruction	3	Odyssey of the Mind · Destination Imagination · Samsung Solve for Tomorrow
Recommend cut	3	Doodle for Google · NCF-Envirothon · National History Day <i>for the 3–5 band only</i>
Flagged — fee / certificate screen, your call	4	The Concord Review · GENIUS Olympiad · Blue Ocean · Conrad Challenge
Flagged — material change to the program	1	FIRST LEGO League (final season)
Listed but on hold	1	NYT student contests (entry 33 — official URL not verifiable)
Checked, confirmed defunct	2	Google Science Fair · Siemens Competition
Checked, could not verify — not listed	1	Rise (Schmidt Futures/Rhodes)
New additions researched and added	10	see "ADDITION" markers below

Of the 40 listed entries, 39 are ready to select from; entry 33 (NYT) is listed with a hold on it.

Dropped at your instruction, recorded so the audit trail is intact: Odyssey of the Mind and Destination Imagination were the two confirmed **mentor-restricted** programs — OM bars outside assistance including *suggesting* a direction to the team, and DI bars all interference from non-team members. Samsung Solve for Tomorrow was verified and qualifying, but its 2026–27 U.S.

close date could not be established. None of the three appear anywhere below.

The single most time-critical item: Regeneron Science Talent Search closes **8:00 PM ET, Thursday 5 November 2026** — about seven weeks out. Any 12th-grade mentee who should apply needs to be identified now.

GRADES 3–5

Copy discipline for this band: nothing here appears on a college application. Every entry below is scored on **pipeline value** only — does the same organization run a 9–12 division, or does this build the specific skill the 9–12 version demands? That field is answered yes/no with a named continuation program for every row.

1. Invention Convention Worldwide (RTX Invention Convention U.S. Nationals)

Organizing body	Invention Convention Worldwide, powered by The Henry Ford
Eligibility	Grades K–12. Teams up to 4 students; team competes in the grade band of its oldest member
Registration deadline	Set by each state/local affiliate (typically winter–spring). For Nationals: 2026 registration opened 1 Apr 2026, closed 7 May 2026, 11:59 pm EST , payment required to complete. 2027 Nationals registration window not yet published
Submission deadline	Affiliate-dependent. Nationals is an in-person event , not a file submission
Total cost	High. Nationals: \$365 entry fee per participant , plus \$390 per additional guest . Student must be onsite at The Henry Ford (Dearborn, MI) with a parent/guardian 18+. Add travel and lodging. Affiliate-level fees vary; many school-run affiliates are free to the student. Fee waiver policy not published — ask the affiliate
Format / artifact	Invention prototype + inventor's logbook + display board + recorded video presentation, judged on a published rubric: Invention Process (40 pts), Invention Impact, Inventor Communication; independent originality score 0–15
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted , with a hard limit at the presentation. Rules are grade-graded: K–2 may use notecards and simple parent prompting (not interview-style); grades 3–4 may use notecards but no adult prompting of any kind ; grades 5–12 no notecards and no adult prompting
Award	Category and grand awards at affiliate, national and global level; patent-support and cash awards vary by affiliate
Pipeline continuation	YES — same organization runs it straight through grade 12, and onward to Invention Convention Globals. Best-in-class pipeline story on this list
Official URL	https://inhub.thehenryford.org/icw/home
Dates for Nationals	2026: 3–5 June 2026. 2027: 9–11 June 2027 , Dearborn, MI
Confidence	Verified: eligibility, team rule, the \$365/\$390 fees, grade-graded prompting rules, rubric weights, 2027 Nationals dates — all from The Henry Ford's own pages and the 2026 official rules PDF (inhub.thehenryford.org/docs/default-source/icw-documents/icusn-2026-official-rules.pdf). Not published yet: 2027 registration window. Inferred: that affiliate-level costs are usually lower — not stated by the organizer

2. FIRST LEGO League — Explore and Challenge [!] FINAL SEASON

Organizing body	FIRST, in partnership with LEGO Education
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Eligibility	2026–27 restructures into two editions. Founders Edition: Explore ages 6–10; Challenge ages 9–16 (varies by country). Future Edition: a K–2 / ages 5–7 option and a grades 3–8 / ages 8–16 option, using LEGO Education Computer Science & AI kits
Registration deadline	Rolling through the season; 2026–27 season game BIOGLOW
Submission deadline	No file submission — performance at regional/state tournaments
Total cost	Team registration increases for 2026–27 ; exact figures not surfaced. Prior-cycle proxy: 2025–26 Explore team (US/Canada) \$140 . Add robot/kit cost, and travel to tournaments. Sales tax newly applies to some teams. Team grants exist: https://www.firstinspires.org/programs/team-grant-opportunities
Format / artifact	Multi-month: robot design and build, plus an Innovation Project (research a real problem, design a solution, present it to judges)
Mentor policy	mentor-required — an adult coach is structural to the program
Award	Trophies and advancement; Core Values, Innovation Project and Robot Design awards. Non-monetary
Pipeline continuation	YES, but changing. Currently feeds FIRST Tech Challenge (grades 7–12) and FIRST Robotics Competition (grades 9–12) — both continue. The LEGO-branded elementary tier does not
Official URL	https://www.firstinspires.org/programs/fll/
[!] Material change	2026–27 BIOGLOW is the final season of FIRST LEGO League. Announced 4 June 2026; the FIRST/LEGO Education partnership ends after this season. LEGO Education launches a successor, " LEGO League ," in August 2027 (https://education.lego.com/en-us/lego-league/program-update/). Implication for the page: listing FLL as a durable 3–5 on-ramp will be wrong within a year. Either list it with an explicit "final season" note, or hold the slot for LEGO League and VEX IQ
Confidence	Verified: final-season announcement and date, two-edition structure, age bands, BIOGLOW name, successor program and launch month, 2025–26 Explore price — all from firstinspires.org / community.firstinspires.org / education.lego.com . Not published in searchable form: exact 2026–27 dollar fees (sit behind the FIRST dashboard and a help-center article)

3. Toshiba/NSTA ExploraVision — existence check passed

Organizing body	Toshiba and the National Science Teaching Association (NSTA)
Eligibility	K–12, four bands: primary K–3, upper elementary 4–6, middle 7–9, high school 10–12 . Band set by the oldest team member. Teams of 2–4
Registration deadline	Registration runs with the submission window; no separate earlier gate
Submission deadline	8:00 PM ET, 27 January 2027 (35th annual / 2026–27 season). Note: this program has extended its deadline in past seasons
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	Team simulates the research process on a technology projected 20 years forward: written description, bibliography, and a set of web-page storyboards. Multi-month, classroom-based
Mentor policy	mentor-required — a coach (teacher or adult) must submit the project on the team's behalf
Award	National 1st place: \$10,000 U.S. Series EE savings bond at maturity per member; 2nd place \$5,000 per member. National winners get an expense-paid trip to a Washington, D.C. awards weekend for the student, parents/guardians (grades K–6) and the coach/mentor. Regional winners receive prizes
Pipeline continuation	YES — same competition runs a 10–12 band; an elementary entrant continues in the same organization with the same artifact type
Official URL	https://www.exploravision.org/

Confidence	Verified — the program is alive. 34th annual ran in 2025–26; the 35th annual submission deadline of 27 Jan 2027 and the K–3/4–6/7–9/10–12 band structure, coach-submits rule, and prize values all come from exploravision.org and NSTA press releases. Noted: organizer states "all students receive an entry prize for participating." This is a participation premium in a free competition, not a pay-for-certificate scheme — it does not trip the pay-to-win screen, but flagging it since it superficially resembles one
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4. Technovation Girls

Organizing body	Technovation
Eligibility	Girls ages 8–18. Beginner 8–12 , Junior 13–15, Senior 16–18
Registration deadline	Registration typically opens in the autumn; 2027 season dates not yet published as of 18 Sep 2026
Submission deadline	Historically late April/May. 2027 date not yet published
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	Multi-month team project: identify a community problem, build a working mobile app, produce a business plan and a pitch video
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — organizer states a mentor is <i>not</i> required, but that teams with mentors learn more and complete projects more easily. Good fit for a mentor handoff without a rule conflict
Award	Regional, semifinalist and finalist recognition; cash prizes at the global level
Pipeline continuation	YES — same organization, Junior (13–15) and Senior (16–18) divisions, same artifact type (app + business plan)
Official URL	https://www.technovation.org/
Confidence	Verified: age divisions, free, mentor-optional language, artifact type. Not published yet: 2027 season calendar — do not put dates on the page for this one until Technovation posts them

5. NFTE World Series of Innovation — now reaches this band

Organizing body	Network for Teaching Entrepreneurship (NFTE)
Eligibility	Ages 5–24 for 2026–27 (expanded). The 13–24 tier is the Impact League
Registration deadline	Rolling; season opened September 2026
Submission deadline	13 December 2026 (<i>one NFTE events page reads 12 December — confirm the exact date before publishing</i>)
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	Choose a sponsor-set Impact Challenge tied to a UN Sustainable Development Goal; submit an innovation concept with a business case
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — classroom and out-of-school educator support is the norm
Award	Cash prizes \$300–\$1,500 ; winners announced spring 2027
Pipeline continuation	YES — one continuous program through age 24; no handoff needed
Official URL	https://innovation.nfte.com/
Confidence	Verified: 2026–27 age expansion to 5–24, SDG challenge structure, prize range, free entry. Conflict: two NFTE pages give 12 vs 13 December. Resolve before publishing

6. VEX IQ Robotics Competition — ADDITION

Added deliberately: with FIRST LEGO League ending, this is the most direct surviving elementary/middle robotics on-ramp with a documentation artifact.

Organizing body	REC Foundation (REC) with VEX Robotics
Eligibility	Elementary and middle school; elementary and middle divisions compete separately
Registration deadline	Rolling by event; 2026–27 game is "Level Up"
Submission deadline	No file submission; engineering notebook is submitted for judging at events
Total cost	Team registration through RobotEvents plus a \$5 platform fee per event registration (\$10 per team at Signature Events from 2025–26 onward); individual event hosts set their own fees on top . Robot kit and field elements are the real cost. Figures vary widely by region
Format / artifact	Multi-month robot design/build/iterate, plus a judged Engineering Notebook documenting design, construction and iteration — this is the artifact, and it is scored against a published rubric
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — adult coaches are standard; judging rubrics reward student-authored documentation
Award	Excellence, Design, Innovate and other judged awards; advancement to VEX Robotics World Championship
Pipeline continuation	YES — VEX V5 Robotics Competition (middle and high school) and VEX U, same organization, same notebook artifact
Official URL	https://roboticseducation.org/vex-iq-competition/
Confidence	Verified: program structure, 2026–27 "Level Up" game, engineering-notebook judging and rubric, \$5/\$10 platform fees. Inferred / highly variable: total cost — kit and event fees are region- and host-specific, so publish a range or omit a figure

CUT — National History Day, for the 3–5 band

National History Day is a strong 6–12 entry (see Grades 6–8) and should stay on the page there. It should not be listed as a grades 3–5 competition.

NHD has exactly **two national divisions: Junior (grades 6–8) and Senior (grades 9–12)**. There is no national elementary division. Some state affiliates separately sponsor 4th/5th-grade participation, and NHD notes that affiliate-sponsored 4th/5th-grade participation does not count against a student's seven-year NHD maximum — but it is affiliate-dependent, not a national program, and we cannot make a national claim about it on a parent-facing page.

Recommendation: list NHD under 6–8 and 9–12 only. If you want a 3–5 history option, write copy that points parents to *their own affiliate* rather than to a division that doesn't exist nationally. Verified on nhd.org.

CUT — Doodle for Google

Why cut	Fails the project-shape filter. The entry is a single piece of artwork plus a short written statement. There is no multi-session mentored project and no research artifact — a student can produce a submission in one sitting. Prestigious and free, but there is no mentor handoff, so it does not serve this page
What it is, for the record	Google; U.S. students grades K–12; free; 17th annual theme "My superpower is ..."; entry deadline around 17 December; five finalists receive \$10,000 scholarships, national winner an additional \$45,000 scholarship plus a \$50,000 technology package for their school; public vote (mid–late April) decides the winner
Official URL	https://doodles.google.com/d4g/

Confidence	Verified on the organizer's own contest-rules and prizes pages. Not pinned: the exact season year attached to the 17 December deadline — another reason not to publish it
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GRADES 6–8

Same caveat applies: middle school results do not appear on a college application. Pipeline value is recorded for every row.

7. 3M Young Scientist Challenge

Organizing body	3M with Discovery Education
Eligibility	Grades 5–8, individual entry
Registration deadline	No separate registration — entry window is the gate
Submission deadline	Entry window runs December to April each year. 2026 cycle closed 30 April 2026 . 2027 dates not yet published as of 18 Sep 2026; expect ~Dec 2026–Apr 2027
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	Stage 1 is a 1–2 minute video describing an original invention or solution to an everyday problem. Stage 2 (finalists only) is a summer-long prototype build
Mentor policy	mentor-required at the finalist stage — and the mentorship is the award. Each of the top 10 finalists is paired with a 3M scientist and given a summer assignment to develop the invention under that mentor
Award	\$25,000 grand prize and the title "America's Top Young Scientist"; top-10 finalists receive the 3M scientist mentorship
Pipeline continuation	NO — 3M YSC has no 9–12 division. Pipeline value is <i>skill-based</i> : the video-pitch-then-prototype sequence is the same shape as Conrad Challenge and Invention Convention at 9–12, and finalists often carry the prototype into ISEF-affiliated fairs. Name those as the continuation, not a 3M program
Official URL	https://youngscientistlab.com/annual-challenge/about-the-challenge/
Confidence	Verified: grades 5–8, video format, 3M-scientist mentorship for top 10, \$25,000 grand prize, December–April window, 30 Apr 2026 close — from youngscientistlab.com and 3M's newsroom. Not published yet: 2027 dates. Inferred: the ISEF continuation claim is our reasoning, not 3M's

8. Thermo Fisher Scientific Junior Innovators Challenge (JIC)

Organizing body	Society for Science
Eligibility	Grades 6, 7, 8. Nomination-gated: student must first complete a science fair project and compete at a Society-affiliated fair in the U.S. or a U.S. territory; the top 10% of 6th–8th graders at those fairs are eligible for nomination
Registration deadline	Governed by the affiliated fair's own calendar (autumn–spring, varies)
Submission deadline	Online application after nomination; JIC application window follows the fair season
Total cost	No JIC entry fee. Cost is whatever the local affiliated fair charges (usually nil to modest). Finals travel is covered for finalists
Format / artifact	A completed science-fair research project, then an online application; Top 300, then 30 finalists compete in team-based challenges

Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — inherits ISEF-family norms: adult/institutional research help is allowed but roles must be disclosed
Award	\$25,000 Thermo Fisher ASCEND Award top prize; 1st place STEM-category awards \$3,500 and 2nd \$2,500 toward educational experiences, both with an iPad; all finalists receive \$500 ; over \$100,000 in total prizes
Pipeline continuation	YES — the strongest on this list. Same organization runs Regeneron ISEF and Regeneron Science Talent Search at 9–12, and the affiliated-fair route a JIC nominee already travels <i>is</i> the ISEF qualification route
Official URL	https://www.societyforscience.org/jic/
Confidence	Verified: nomination mechanism and top-10% rule, grade eligibility, Top 300 / 30 finalists structure, all prize values — from societyforscience.org/jic/ . Not pinned: the 2027 application window (driven by affiliated-fair calendars)

9. eCYBERMISSION

Organizing body	U.S. Army Educational Outreach Program (AEOP), administered with NSTA
Eligibility	Grades 6–9. Teams of 2–4 students plus an adult Team Advisor
Registration deadline	24 February 2027 — Team Advisors and students must be fully registered on complete teams by this date (2026–27 season)
Submission deadline	Mission Folder submission follows registration; exact 2026–27 date not surfaced — the site shows a rolling status bar of upcoming deadlines
Total cost	Free , and fully virtual — no travel required to compete
Format / artifact	The Mission Folder : a structured written report in which the team identifies a problem in its own community and either investigates it with science or solves it with engineering
Mentor policy	mentor-required — an adult Team Advisor is mandatory and is the registering party
Award	Regional and national awards; Team Advisor Mini-Grants fund project supplies and pay the advisor a professional stipend
Pipeline continuation	Partial YES — grade 9 is inside the eligibility band, so a student can carry it into high school, but AEOP's 10–12 offerings are internships and apprenticeships rather than a same-name competition. The Mission Folder is also a clean precursor to a JSHS paper
Official URL	https://www.ecybermission.com/
Confidence	Verified: grades 6–9, team size, mandatory Team Advisor, free/virtual, the 24 Feb 2027 registration close, Mission Folder as the artifact, Mini-Grant structure — from ecybermission.com and usaeop.com . Not published in searchable form: the Mission Folder submission date and national award dollar values

10. Future City

Organizing body	DiscoverE
Eligibility	Grades 6–8
Registration deadline	Set per region; 31 October 2026 for the 2026–27 season in at least one region (Ohio). Check the specific region — this is the deadline families miss
Submission deadline	Regional competition dates in January; deliverables due ahead of the regional

Total cost	Lowest-cost serious entry on this list. \$25 per organization — covering every team that organization enters, one to one hundred — plus a \$100 cap on model and presentation supplies , plus travel to the regional. Regional winners receive airfare and hotel for five (three presenting students, the educator and the mentor) to Finals
Format / artifact	Multi-month, four deliverables: a written essay , a scale model , a project plan , and a live presentation to judges . 2026–27 theme: " Fire Resilient Future " (engineer an urban environment that prevents, protects against and recovers from wildfire)
Mentor policy	mentor-required — an engineer mentor is part of the standard team structure, and the mentor is explicitly funded as one of the five travellers to Finals. Best structural fit for BlueRobins on the 6–8 list
Award	Regional awards; national finals in Washington, D.C.
Pipeline continuation	YES — Future City High School , same organization, grades 9–12, teams of 3–5 plus one adult coach. Two tracks: Program Access, and Competition Access (+\$150 to switch before Qualification Round deliverables). High-school teams build a digital city model in Revit plus an essay, judged in a virtual Qualification Round; top 20 advance to Finals in Washington, D.C.
Official URL	https://futurecity.org/ · High school: https://futurecity.org/future-city-high-school/
Confidence	Verified: 2026–27 theme, grades, four deliverables, the \$25/organization and \$100 model cap, regional-winner travel covering the mentor, and the full High School division structure and \$150 Competition Access fee — from futurecity.org . Region-specific: the 31 Oct 2026 registration close was confirmed for one region; verify the family's own region before publishing a date

11. Zero Robotics

Organizing body	MIT (with NASA)
Eligibility	Separate middle school and high school tournaments
Registration deadline	High school 2026 tournament: registration ran 1 Oct – 28 Nov 2025 . Middle school 2026: registration opened spring, closed May 2026. 2027 high school season dates not yet posted as of 18 Sep 2026 — historically opens 1 October, so this is imminent
Submission deadline	Tournament concludes: HS 2026 ended 15 Mar 2026; MS 2026 summer program ended 8 Aug 2026
Total cost	Free to compete (programming is done through MIT's online IDE)
Format / artifact	Teams write flight software for NASA's Astrobee free-flying robots; finalist code runs aboard the International Space Station. 2026 HS game "Galactic Greenhouse"; 2026 MS game "Asteroid-Bee"
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — teams are typically coached by a teacher or an MIT-affiliated mentor
Award	Finals run live on the ISS; recognition rather than cash
Pipeline continuation	YES — middle school tournament feeds the high school tournament, same program
Official URL	https://zerorobotics.mit.edu/
Confidence	Verified: the program is active — it was paused when the SPHERES robots retired in 2020 and relaunched on Astrobee in Winter 2025 ; 2026 season names and dates confirmed from zerorobotics.mit.edu and MIT Media Lab. Not published yet: 2027 dates. Worth re-checking in early October

12. Scholastic Art & Writing Awards

Organizing body	Alliance for Young Artists & Writers
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Eligibility	Grades 7–12, age 13+ , residing in the U.S., U.S. territories, military bases, or Canada (excluding Quebec). 28 categories
Registration deadline	2027 season opened 1 October 2026
Submission deadline	Regional, and this is the trap. The first regional deadline is 1 December 2026 ; other regions run as late as 4 January 2027 . Deadline depends on the student's region
Total cost	\$15 per individual entry; \$40 per portfolio entry (as of 1 Oct 2026). Fee waivers are available where fees are a barrier
Format / artifact	Juried portfolio or single work across art and writing categories; regional adjudication then national
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted, with a strict originality rule. Work must be original and based on the student's own ideas, not copied and not AI-generated ; violations lead to disqualification and can trigger recall of all of that teen's awards for the year. Teacher and mentor guidance is normal; authorship must be the student's
Award	Regional and National Gold/Silver Keys and Gold Medals; scholarships including Best-in-Grade; National Student Poets and Portfolio awards
Pipeline continuation	YES — the program itself runs to grade 12; a 7th-grade entrant stays in the same competition for six years
Official URL	https://www.artandwriting.org/
Confidence	Verified: grade/age eligibility, 2027 opening date, first and last regional deadlines, the \$15/\$40 fees and the existence of waivers, originality and anti-AI terms — from artandwriting.org . Pay-to-win screen: fees exist but this is not a pay-to-win award — judging is juried and competitive, waivers are offered, and no entrant receives an award for paying. Keep it

13. Congressional App Challenge

Organizing body	Congressional Internet Caucus / U.S. House of Representatives
Eligibility	Middle or high school student at time of submission; individuals or teams up to 4 . Compete in the district where you live or where you attend school; at least half a team must be eligible in that district. U.S. residents; no citizenship requirement
Registration deadline	Registration open from 1 May 2026; no separate gate ahead of submission
Submission deadline	26 October 2026, 12:00 pm ET (2026 challenge ran 1 May – 26 Oct 2026). ~5 weeks out — the nearest deadline on the 6–8 list
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	An original working app, plus a demo video. AI tools are permitted only if fully disclosed in the submission materials, and may not constitute the entirety of the technical development
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — teacher and mentor support is expected and normal; the organizer's own data notes most entrants need some teacher or mentor assistance
Award	One winner per congressional district. Winning apps eligible for display in the Capitol Building and on House.gov; winners invited to #HouseOfCode on Capitol Hill each spring (360 students from 220+ districts last year). No cash prize
Pipeline continuation	YES — one program covering middle through high school
Official URL	https://www.congressionalappchallenge.us/
Confidence	Verified: all of the above from congressionalappchallenge.us , including the 2026 rules PDF (.../2026/05/2026-CAC-Rules.pdf)

14. C-SPAN StudentCam — ADDITION

Organizing body	C-SPAN
Eligibility	Grades 6–12. Middle School category (6–8) and High School category (9–12). Individuals or teams of 2 or 3
Registration deadline	No separate registration
Submission deadline	20 January 2027, 11:59 pm PST (23rd annual competition)
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	A 5:00–6:00 minute documentary on the annual theme, which must include C-SPAN video clips relevant to the topic. Films under 5:00 or over 6:00 are disqualified in round one. Genuinely multi-month: research, interviews, shooting, editing
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — teacher advisers are formally recognised and separately awarded
Award	\$100,000 total in cash prizes annually across the top 150 documentaries, plus prizes for the teacher advisers of the top 50. Grand Prize: \$5,000 to the student(s) and \$750 to the teacher/school
Pipeline continuation	YES — same competition, High School category, identical artifact
Official URL	https://www.studentcam.org/
Confidence	Verified: grade categories, the 20 Jan 2027 deadline and time zone, the 5–6 minute rule and disqualification policy, the C-SPAN-footage requirement, team sizes, full prize structure — from studentcam.org . Not yet announced at time of check: the 2027 theme (C-SPAN announces it in summer; may now be posted)

15. NASA TechRise Student Challenge — ADDITION

Organizing body	NASA, administered by Future Engineers
Eligibility	Grades 6–12. Minimum 4 students per team plus one team lead; all students on a team must attend the same U.S. public, private or charter school
Registration deadline	Entry is the gate
Submission deadline	2 November 2026, 11:59 pm PT (2026–27 challenge)
Total cost	Free. Winning teams are <i>paid</i> , not charged
Format / artifact	Propose an experiment; 60 winning teams then design, build and fly it. Experiments must be mailed to Future Engineers by 19 May 2027 , flying on a NASA-sponsored high-altitude balloon in summer 2027
Mentor policy	mentor-required — a team lead (educator) is mandatory; NASA technical support accompanies the build
Award	\$1,500 per winning team to build the experiment, a starter kit including a flight box, and an assigned flight slot
Pipeline continuation	YES — one program spanning 6–12, and the build phase is a genuine engineering-research apprenticeship
Official URL	https://www.futureengineers.org/nasatechrise · NASA: https://www.nasa.gov/centers-and-facilities/armstrong/nasa-techrise-student-challenge/
Confidence	Verified: 2026–27 deadline of 2 Nov 2026, the 19 May 2027 hardware date, summer 2027 flight, 60 teams, \$1,500 award, team-size and same-school rules, grades 6–12. [!] Sourcing caveat: the strongest single confirmation of the 2026–27 dates came from the USAGov challenge listing (usa.gov/challenges/nasa-techrise-student-challenge) — a government listing, not an aggregator blog, but still not the organizer's own page. Confirm on futureengineers.org before publishing , especially given the 2 November proximity

16. Genes in Space — ADDITION

Organizing body	Genes in Space (Boeing, miniPCR bio, ISS National Laboratory, New England Biolabs)
Eligibility	Grades 7–12 , attending a U.S. public, private or home school; enrolled to study in the U.S. or U.S. territories. Individuals or teams
Registration deadline	Entry is the gate
Submission deadline	2026 cycle closed 14 April 2026, 11:59 pm PDT . 2027 date not yet published as of 18 Sep 2026 — expect ~April 2027
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	A written proposal for a biotechnology experiment to be run aboard the ISS. Five finalist teams are selected; the winning experiment is actually flown and performed by astronauts in orbit
Mentor policy	mentor-required — every team must have an adult sponsor; entrants under 13 must have an adult sponsor submit on their behalf. Finalists are paired with Harvard and MIT scientist mentors to refine the proposal
Award	Winning experiment flown to and conducted on the ISS; finalist mentorship; presentation at the ISS Research and Development Conference
Pipeline continuation	YES — band runs 7–12; the proposal artifact is exactly what ISEF, JSHS and STS reward at 9–12
Official URL	https://www.genesinspace.org/
Confidence	Verified: grades 7–12, U.S. school requirement, adult-sponsor requirement, under-13 submission rule, 2026 deadline, ISS flight outcome — from genesinspace.org . Not published yet: 2027 deadline. Inferred: the specific "Harvard and MIT" mentor description reflects the program's standard finalist mentorship; confirm wording before quoting it

17. The Junior Academy (NY Academy of Sciences) — ADDITION

Organizing body	The New York Academy of Sciences
Eligibility	Students ages 13–17 (middle and high school)
Registration deadline	Rolling admission to the Junior Academy; Innovation Challenges run each Fall and Spring semester
Submission deadline	End of each 10-week Innovation Challenge
Total cost	Free for admitted students (admission is competitive)
Format / artifact	Virtual 10-week Innovation Challenge: international student teams design a research-driven solution to a global problem set by a corporate or NGO sponsor, and submit a full project
Mentor policy	mentor-required — and this is the structural reason to list it . Every team is assigned a STEM mentor (graduate student, postdoc or working professional). The Academy actively recruits mentors; the mentor application deadline is 2 July
Award	Winning-team recognition, sponsor engagement, Academy credential
Pipeline continuation	YES — the 13–17 band spans middle into high school within one program
Official URL	https://www.nyas.org/learning/high-school-research-programs/the-junior-academy/
Confidence	Verified: 10-week Fall/Spring challenge structure, assigned-mentor model, ages 13–17, mentor application deadline of 2 July — from nyas.org . Not verified: whether any student-side fee applies, and exact 2026–27 challenge dates. [!] Note of interest: BlueRobins mentors are themselves eligible to apply as Junior Academy mentors — a possible partnership angle beyond the page

GRADES 9–12

18. Regeneron International Science and Engineering Fair (ISEF)

Organizing body	Society for Science
Eligibility	Grades 9–12 or equivalent. Must win the right to attend at a Regeneron ISEF-affiliated fair . Team projects: maximum 3 members , and the ISEF team must be the same members who competed at the affiliated fair
Registration deadline	Set by the affiliated fair (autumn through spring). Find one: https://findafair.societyforscience.org/
Submission deadline	Affiliated-fair deadline governs. Critically, ISEF paperwork (research plan, approval forms) must be completed before research begins — this is the deadline students actually miss
Total cost	No ISEF entry fee; affiliated fairs charge little or nothing. Finalist travel is normally funded by the affiliated fair
Format / artifact	Original research project: research plan, abstract, paper, poster/display, and judged oral defence
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted, with mandatory disclosure. Research alongside adult researchers at an institution is explicitly permitted, but "clarity and adequate acknowledgment of an individual's role and independence versus work being done by the collective laboratory" is required throughout. Governed by the International Rules for Pre-College Science Research (2027 edition published)
Award	2026 scale: ~\$9 million across awards, scholarships and internships. George D. Yancopoulos Innovator Award \$100,000 ; two Regeneron Young Scientist Awards \$75,000 each; Gordon E. Moore Award \$50,000 ; Leighton & Berger Family Prize for STEM Excellence \$50,000 ; Craig R. Barrett, Robert Horvitz, Peggy Scripps and Mary Sue Coleman awards \$10,000 each; plus category grand awards and special awards
Official URL	https://www.societyforscience.org/isef/ · Rules: https://www.societyforscience.org/isef/international-rules/
2027 event	Los Angeles, California, 8–14 May 2027
Confidence	Verified: grade eligibility, affiliated-fair gate, 3-member team cap, same-members rule, the disclosure language on institutional mentorship, 2027 dates and location, and every award value listed — from societyforscience.org . Inferred: the "paperwork before research begins" emphasis is our reading of the International Rules, correct in substance but phrased by us

19. Regeneron Science Talent Search (STS) **[SOON]** NEAREST MAJOR DEADLINE

Organizing body	Society for Science
Eligibility	Students in their final year of secondary school in the U.S. and its territories, regardless of citizenship ; U.S. citizens attending school abroad may also qualify
Registration deadline	Same as submission — single application gate
Submission deadline	[URGENT] 8:00 PM ET, Thursday 5 November 2026 for the 2027 competition. Recommendations are due at the same moment — "no exceptions." Recommenders must therefore be lined up now
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	Full original research project plus a substantial written application: research report, essays, recommendations, transcript
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted and effectively expected — Society for Science publishes dedicated guidance for educators and mentors supporting entrants (https://www.societyforscience.org/regeneron-sts/sts-adults/)

Award	\$3.1 million annually. 300 Scholars receive \$2,000 each (with a matching award to their schools); 40 Finalists receive at least \$25,000 and a week in Washington, D.C.; first place \$250,000 — the largest science prize available to a U.S. high school student
Official URL	https://www.societyforscience.org/regeneron-sts/ · Apply: https://stsapply.societyforscience.org/
Confidence	Verified — highest confidence row in this document. Deadline, time, the no-exceptions recommendation rule, eligibility, and every award figure come from societyforscience.org's own STS pages

20. Junior Science and Humanities Symposium (JSHS)

Organizing body	Junior Science and Humanities Symposium, sponsored by the U.S. Department of Defense; regionals hosted at universities
Eligibility	Grades 9–12 , public, private or home school. Must be a U.S. citizen or legal permanent resident — the one hard citizenship gate in this document
Registration deadline	Set by each regional symposium. Information and dates for 2026–27 regional events post in autumn 2026 — i.e. now
Submission deadline	Regional; abstract and research paper submitted ahead of the symposium
Total cost	No cost to register or participate in a regional symposium
Format / artifact	Original STEM research: abstract, full research paper, and an oral presentation or poster presentation with judged defence. University-hosted, peer-reviewed in character
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted, with formal mandatory disclosure. JSHS publishes a " Statement of Outside Assistance " document alongside its Rules of Competition — both in a 2027 edition. Mentored research is expected; the disclosure is the mechanism
Award	Regional awards; top two regional delegates advance to the National Symposium to compete for military-sponsored undergraduate tuition scholarships
Official URL	https://www.jshs.org/ · Rules: https://www.jshs.org/national-symposium/rules-categories/ · Find a region: https://www.jshs.org/students/find-your-region/
Confidence	Verified: eligibility including citizenship, free participation, university-hosted regionals, oral/poster format, the existence of 2027 Rules of Competition and 2027 Statement of Outside Assistance, scholarship structure — from jshs.org. Not published yet: 2027 National Symposium dates and location, and 2026–27 regional deadlines (organizer states these post in autumn 2026). Prior-cycle reference only: the 63rd National Symposium ran 22–26 April 2025 in Chantilly, Virginia

21. Davidson Fellows Scholarship

Organizing body	Davidson Institute
Eligibility	Age 18 or younger as of the application deadline; no minimum age. U.S. citizen residing in the U.S., U.S. Permanent Resident residing in the U.S., or stationed overseas on active U.S. military duty
Registration deadline	Same as submission
Submission deadline	2027 application opens Fall 2026; 2027 deadline not yet published as of 18 Sep 2026. Prior-cycle proxy: the 2026 deadline was 18 February 2026
Total cost	Free

Format / artifact	A completed significant piece of work in one of: Science, Technology, Engineering, Mathematics, Literature, Music, Philosophy, Outside the Box. The bar is explicit: work at or close to college-graduate level , with a depth of knowledge in the field and the potential to benefit society. <i>Not offered:</i> vocal, dance, theater, photography, visual arts
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — the work must be demonstrably the student's own creation; mentored research is standard among Fellows
Award	\$100,000 / \$50,000 / \$25,000 scholarships. [!] These amounts were increased — older write-ups (and many aggregators) still say \$50,000/\$25,000/\$10,000. Use the current figures
Official URL	https://www.davidsongifted.org/gifted-programs/fellows-scholarship/
Confidence	Verified: current award tiers, age and residency rules, the eight categories and the excluded disciplines, the graduate-level standard — from davidsongifted.org . Not published yet: the 2027 deadline

22. MIT THINK Scholars Program

Organizing body	MIT THINK Scholars Program (student-run, MIT)
Eligibility	High school students residing in the United States
Registration deadline	Same as submission
Submission deadline	2027 deadline not surfaced as of 18 Sep 2026. Program guidelines are published per cycle at <a href="https://think.mit.edu/static_files/THINK_Program_Guidelines_<year>.pdf">think.mit.edu/static_files/THINK_Program_Guidelines_<year>.pdf (2026 edition exists)
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	A written research proposal for a novel science, technology or engineering idea — not a completed project. The program is explicitly designed for students who have researched the background thoroughly but lack the resources and guidance to execute . Applicants must address how the project would benefit from THINK's funding and mentorship
Mentor policy	mentor-required — the mentorship is the prize. Finalists receive mentorship from MIT students, professors and researchers in their field, plus project funding and a trip to MIT
Award	Project funding, MIT mentorship, visit to MIT campus
Official URL	https://think.mit.edu/
Why it matters for BlueRobins	This is the one entry on the page that <i>rewards</i> a student for having a project they can't yet do alone. It is the most natural handoff point of anything listed
Confidence	Verified: proposal-not-project format, the "lack resources/guidance" framing, US high school eligibility, the mentorship-and-funding award, per-cycle guidelines PDFs — from think.mit.edu . Not published yet: 2027 deadline (historically around 1 January — do not publish that; verify)

23. U.S. Stockholm Junior Water Prize

Organizing body	Water Environment Federation (U.S. national competition); Stockholm International Water Institute (international final)
Eligibility	Grades 9–12 , and must have reached age 15 by 1 August of the competition year. Teams of up to 2. Residents of the 50 states, D.C. and Puerto Rico only
Registration deadline	State competition entry. 2026 cycle: regional winners and self-nominated students had to enter the State Competition by 15 April 2026 . 2027 dates not yet published

Submission deadline	Online entry form plus research paper submitted electronically, file under 2 MB
Total cost	Free to enter at state level; travel to the national finals
Format / artifact	A water-related original research project with a full written research paper; state competition, then national judging, then international
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — mentored laboratory and field research is the norm, consistent with the ISEF-family disclosure model
Award	State prizes vary (published per state at wef.org/globalassets/assets-wef/3-membership/stockholm-junior-water-prize/sjwp-eligibility/state-contacts-awards-and-deadlines.pdf); U.S. national winner advances to the international Stockholm Junior Water Prize
Official URL	https://www.wef.org/sjwp/
Confidence	Verified: grade and age-15 rule, 2-student team cap, state residency limits, paper and 2 MB file rule, the 15 Apr 2026 state deadline and the 2026 finals structure (virtual state-winner judging first two weeks of May; top 20 to in-person finals 8–10 June 2026, Chicago) — from wef.org . Not published yet: 2027 calendar. Not verified: the international prize value — do not publish a figure for it

24. National History Day

Organizing body	National History Day
Eligibility	Junior Division grades 6–8; Senior Division grades 9–12. (No national elementary division — see the 3–5 cut above)
Registration deadline	Set by each affiliate , via the affiliate's own contest website. This is the field families miss, and NHD does not centralise it
Submission deadline	Affiliate contest dates run winter–spring; national contest follows
Total cost	Affiliate-dependent; national contest participation carries travel costs to College Park
Format / artifact	Year-long original historical research on the annual theme, presented in one of five categories: paper (individual only), exhibit , documentary , performance , website (individual or group). Annotated bibliography and process paper required
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — teacher-supervised research is the standard model; work must be the student's own
Award	Affiliate and national awards; special prizes
2027 specifics	Theme: "Innovation in History: Impact, Influence, Change." National Contest 13–17 June 2027 , University of Maryland, College Park
Pipeline note (for the 6–8 listing)	YES — Senior Division, same organization, same artifact categories. Also: affiliate-sponsored 4th/5th-grade participation does not count against the seven-year NHD participation maximum
Official URL	https://nhd.org/
Confidence	Verified: two-division structure, five categories and the paper-is-individual-only rule, 2027 theme, 2027 national contest dates and venue, affiliate-set deadlines, the seven-year maximum and the 4th/5th-grade exemption — from nhd.org . Not centrally published: affiliate registration deadlines and fees

25. Conrad Challenge cost flag

Organizing body	Conrad Foundation
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Eligibility	Ages 13–18 ; teams of 2–5
Registration deadline	Activation Stage (team formation and registration) — 2026–27 dates not yet surfaced
Submission deadline	Four stages: Activation → Lean Canvas → Innovation → Power Pitch at the Innovation Summit in April
Total cost	[FLAG] Activation and Lean Canvas stages are free. The Innovation Stage carries a \$499 per-team entry fee . Attending the in-person Innovation Summit costs a further \$499 per participant , plus travel and lodging. A five-student team reaching the Summit therefore faces roughly \$3,000 in fees alone , before travel
Format / artifact	Lean Canvas, then a full innovation package — technical development, market analysis, business model — then a live pitch to judges
Mentor policy	mentor-required — every team must have a coach aged 18+ as adult supervisor
Award	Pete Conrad Scout / Innovator awards, seed funding and in-kind support for winning teams
Official URL	https://www.conradchallenge.org/
Your call	This is not a pay-to-win award — judging is genuinely competitive and the early stages are free, so a student can test their idea at zero cost. But the fee structure is steep and back-loaded onto the families whose kids do best , which is exactly the kind of surprise that damages trust if it isn't disclosed up front. If you list it, publish the \$499 + \$499 structure in the row itself
Confidence	Verified: ages, team size, required 18+ coach, the four stages, and both \$499 fees — from conradchallenge.org. Not published yet: 2026–27 stage deadlines

26. Diamond Challenge

Organizing body	Horn Entrepreneurship, University of Delaware
Eligibility	Teams of 2–4 high school students aged 14–18 at the submission deadline
Registration deadline	Teams develop concepts from September ; registration precedes the round-one deadline
Submission deadline	Three rounds; judging runs February–April , culminating at the Limitless World Summit. Exact 2027 round-one deadline not published as of 18 Sep 2026
Total cost	Free to enter — confirmed on the organizer's own site. Travel to the Summit for finalists
Format / artifact	Round one: a written concept narrative plus an introductory video . Later rounds: full venture development and live pitch. Two tracks — Business Innovation (solve a customer problem profitably) and Social Innovation (solve a social or environmental problem)
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — adult advisers are normal; not verified as required
Award	\$100,000 prize pool ; awards to the top three teams in each of the two tracks
Official URL	https://diamondchallenge.org/
Why it's a good fit	University-hosted, free, written-artifact first round, and two tracks — the social track suits mentees whose interests aren't commercial. Clean contrast to Conrad on cost
Confidence	Verified: team size and ages, free entry, two tracks, \$100K pool, round-one artifact, Feb–Apr judging window — from diamondchallenge.org. Not published yet: the 2027 deadline. Not verified: whether a mentor is required

27. Blue Ocean Student Entrepreneur Competition certificate flag

Organizing body	Blue Ocean Student Entrepreneur Competition
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Eligibility	Enrolled in high school (secondary school) at registration ; students who graduate before the deadline may still submit. Individuals or teams up to 5 . International
Registration deadline	Registration ahead of submission; free
Submission deadline	[CONFIRMED] 21 February 2027 — one of the few firm 2027 dates already published
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	A video pitch under 5 minutes , in English, presenting an original business concept built on blue-ocean strategy. A free Blue Ocean Mini-Course supports preparation
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — teacher involvement is formally recognised through the Teacher Champion awards
Award	Cash prizes to top teams; \$500 to each of three Blue Ocean Teacher Champions; Top 10 receive a Certificate of Outstanding Achievement
Official URL	https://blueoceancompetition.org/
Why this is flagged	The organizer awards a Certificate of Participation to every participant who submits a pitch . That trips your "every entrant receives a certificate" screen as literally written. But the underlying concern doesn't apply : entry is free, there is no nomination fee, nothing is sold to entrants, and the real awards (Top 10, cash) are juried and selective. Our read: the screen exists to catch pay-for-prestige operations, and this isn't one — keep it, but never let the participation certificate appear in marketing copy as an "award." Your call
Confidence	Verified : the 21 Feb 2027 deadline, eligibility and graduation clause, team cap of 5, under-5-minute English video rule, free entry, Teacher Champion awards, and both certificate tiers — from blueoceancompetition.org

28. NFTE World Series of Innovation (9–12 tier)

See the full entry under Grades 3–5 (#5) — one program, ages 5–24. For this band the relevant tier is the **Impact League (ages 13–24)**. Submission **13 December 2026** (*confirm 12 vs 13*); free; cash prizes **\$300–\$1,500**; winners announced spring 2027.

<https://innovation.nfte.com/>

29. Breakthrough Junior Challenge **[CLOSED]** cycle just closed

Organizing body	Breakthrough Prize Foundation with Khan Academy
Eligibility	Ages 13–18 (must have turned 13 by the competition's opening date). Individual entry
Registration deadline	Same as submission
Submission deadline	The 2026 cycle opened 11 May 2026 and closed 15 September 2026, 11:59 pm PDT — three days before this document was compiled. The next cycle is expected to open around May 2027
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	An original video up to 2 minutes explaining a concept or theory in science or mathematics engagingly and imaginatively
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — individual authorship required; the winner names an inspiring teacher who is separately awarded
Award	\$250,000 college scholarship to the winner, up to \$100,000 toward a science lab at the winner's school, and \$50,000 to a teacher the winner names
Official URL	https://breakthroughjuniorchallenge.org/

Judgment call worth noting	This is the most borderline keep in this document against your project-shape filter. A 2-minute video is a real produced artifact and strong entries take weeks of scripting, animation and revision — but a student <i>could</i> film something in an afternoon. It survives on artifact quality, not required duration. Flagging so the choice is yours rather than silent
Confidence	Verified: exact 2026 open and close datetimes, age rule, 2-minute format, and all three prize components — from breakthroughjuniorchallenge.org and breakthroughprize.org. Inferred: the ~May 2027 reopening, from the prior cycle's pattern

30. Bow Seat Ocean Awareness Contest

Organizing body	Bow Seat Ocean Awareness Programs (Creative Action for Conservation)
Eligibility	Ages 11–18 worldwide, enrolled in middle or high school (or homeschool equivalent). Junior Division 11–14; Senior Division 15–18. Students who have begun college are not eligible
Registration deadline	No separate registration
Submission deadline	2026 cycle closed 8 June 2026, 11:59 pm EDT . 2027 theme was due to be announced in September 2026 — likely posted now; 2027 deadline expected early June 2027. Verify before publishing
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	Categories: Visual Art (Handcrafted), Visual Art (Digital), Creative Writing, Film, Interactive & Multimedia, Performing Arts (Music & Dance), Poetry & Spoken Word. Entries pair the creative work with a written reflection grounded in environmental research
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — teacher and mentor guidance is encouraged
Award	Scholarship awards up to \$1,500 ; the " We All Rise Prize " offers ten \$500 awards (five per division) to U.S. students who identify as Black, Indigenous and/or Latine
Official URL	https://bowseat.org/programs/ocean-awareness-contest/
Confidence	Verified: age bands and both divisions, category list, college-enrollment exclusion, free entry, award values including We All Rise, and the 8 June 2026 close — from bowseat.org. Not yet published at time of check: 2027 theme and deadline

31. John F. Kennedy Profile in Courage Essay Contest

Organizing body	John F. Kennedy Presidential Library and Museum Foundation
Eligibility	U.S. high school students grades 9–12 (public, private, parochial, home school); U.S. students under 20 in a high school correspondence/GED program; the 50 states, D.C. and U.S. territories; U.S. citizens attending school overseas
Registration deadline	Registration form (which names the nominating teacher) precedes essay submission
Submission deadline	The 2027 contest opens 1 September. [!] The deadline date rendered incompletely in the organizer's own indexed page ("[deadline date], 2027") — historically mid-January. Do not publish a date for this one without opening the page
Total cost	Free
Format / artifact	Original research essay, 700–1,000 words (parenthetical citations and bibliography excluded from the count), on an act of political courage by a U.S. elected official; full citation and bibliography required

Mentor policy	mentor-required — and unusually explicit. Every student must name a nominating teacher on the registration form. The nominating teacher's stated role is to support and advise the student during writing and to read the essay and suggest improvements before submission. The teacher must still be teaching at the student's high school
Award	First place \$10,000 ; second \$3,000 ; three finalists \$1,000 each; fifteen honorable mentions. Top five and honorable mentions receive a hardcover copy of <i>Profiles in Courage</i>
Official URL	https://www.jfklibrary.org/learn/education/profile-in-courage-essay-contest
Why it's a standout for us	The rules don't merely permit a mentor — they require a named adult to read and improve the draft. That is the cleanest mentor mandate of any writing contest on this list
Confidence	Verified: eligibility including the under-20 GED clause and overseas-citizen clause, word limits and citation exclusion, the nominating-teacher requirement and its described role, all award values, and the 1 September opening — from jfklibrary.org. [!] Not verified: the submission deadline itself (source text incomplete)

32. The Concord Review fee flag — your call

Organizing body	The Concord Review, Inc.
Eligibility	Secondary school students worldwide
Registration deadline	None separate
Submission deadline	Quarterly, rolling: 1 February (Summer issue), 1 May (Fall), 1 August (Winter), 1 November (Spring). An essay is considered for the next three issues
Total cost	[FLAG] A submission fee is required and must be paid as part of the online submission. It includes a one-year eBook subscription to the journal and the next four issues. Amount: approximately \$70 (some sources say \$75); print upgrade reported at \$110 U.S. / \$150 international. These figures come from third-party guides, not from tcr.org — the organizer's fee page did not surface. Verify the amount directly before publishing anything
Format / artifact	A long-form original history research paper (typically 5,000–8,000 words with full apparatus). Accepted on a rolling basis; authors notified by letter the month before publication. Published quarterly in September, December, March and June
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — teacher-supervised research is the norm
Award	Publication in a peer-recognised journal — the award is the credential, not cash. The Concord Review separately operates the National Writing Board (https://tcr.org/nwb), a paid independent assessment service — a distinct product, not a prize
Official URL	https://tcr.org/ · Submit: https://tcr.org/submit
Why this is flagged, and what we think	Your screen excludes anything "where publication requires payment." Read literally, TCR trips it. Read by intent, the case is different: the fee is for submission , not for publication; the acceptance rate is low and the review is genuinely selective; and it is one of the few student publications admissions readers actually respect. The real risk is different from the one your rule was written to catch — it's that paying ~\$70 buys a rejection for most students. Our recommendation: keep it, but write the copy so families understand the fee is a non-refundable submission cost with a low acceptance rate. Do not describe the included subscription as a benefit of winning. Your call
Confidence	Verified from tcr.org: the four quarterly deadlines, the three-issue consideration window, that a fee is required and includes a subscription, rolling acceptance and the notification process, publication months. LOW CONFIDENCE (third-party only): the \$70/\$75/\$110/\$150 figures

33. New York Times student contests [!] cannot verify — do not list yet

Organizing body	The New York Times Learning Network
Status of verification	[BLOCKED] Blocked. <code>nytimes.com</code> refuses our crawler — the search tool returns an explicit error that the domain is not accessible to its user agent, and direct fetching is blocked by the egress proxy. Every fact available about the 2026–27 lineup came from aggregator sites , which your brief correctly tells us not to trust
Official URL	[!] Deliberately left blank. The Learning Network's contest calendar URL was not confirmable from a source we're permitted to rely on, and per your rule a blank cell beats a wrong link
What aggregators claim (<i>unverified, recorded only so you know what to check</i>)	Contests open to students ages 13–19 in middle or high school worldwide; 2026–27 lineup reported as including a STEM Interview contest (6 Jan–17 Feb 2027), an Open Letter contest (17 Feb–31 Mar 2027), a Podcast contest (31 Mar–12 May 2027) and a three-window Summer Reading contest; the 2025–26 "Growing Up With AI" multimedia contest reportedly replaced by a visual-art-focused contest
Fit assessment (independent of the date problem)	Mixed. The Podcast and STEM Interview contests produce real media artifacts over several weeks and would qualify. Short-turnaround written contests and the weekly Summer Reading contest are closer to one-sitting entries and would not. If you list NYT at all, list the specific qualifying contests, not "NYT student contests" as a block
Recommendation	Hold. One human visit to the Learning Network's contest calendar resolves both the URL and the dates in about two minutes. Until then this should not go on a parent-facing page

34. All American High School Film Festival

Organizing body	All American High School Film Festival
Eligibility	The film's director(s) must have been in high school or younger when the film was produced. Middle school students are eligible. Open internationally. Recently graduated seniors may create and submit after graduation, up to the final deadline
Registration deadline	Submission window opens around 1 November ; entries are accepted in tiers
Submission deadline	2026 cycle: free submission deadline Monday 2 March 2026; final deadline 3 July 2026, 11:59 pm ET. 2027 dates not yet posted as of 18 Sep 2026
Total cost	Free if submitted by the early "free submission" deadline — a genuinely useful fact for families. Entry fees apply after that window; the amounts did not surface and must be verified. The separate NYC Film Invitational costs \$250 (teams of 5 or fewer) or \$500 (6+). Festival is held in New York City — budget travel and lodging for attendance
Format / artifact	A completed short film, submitted by category. Students may submit as many films in as many categories as they wish
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — film teachers and advisers are standard
Award	Official Selection status, category awards, screenings in New York City, industry exposure
[!] Correction to the seed list	The official domain is hsfilmfest.com , not <code>aahsff.org</code>
Official URL	https://www.hsfilmfest.com/ · Rules: https://www.hsfilmfest.com/rulesandcategories
Confidence	Verified: eligibility including middle schoolers and recent graduates, the free-then-paid deadline structure with 2026 dates, unlimited category submissions, Film Invitational pricing, NYC venue — from <code>hsfilmfest.com</code> . Not verified: standard entry fee amounts. Not published yet: 2027 dates

35. FIRST Robotics Competition / FIRST Tech Challenge

Organizing body	FIRST
Eligibility	FTC: ages 12–18 / grades 7–12. FRC: ages 14–18 / grades 9–12
Registration deadline	2026–27 season is live: FTC "BIOBUZZ" presented by RTX kicked off 12 September 2026 ; FRC 2026–27 game is "BIOCORE." Payment due date for registration options that include opt-outs: 17 November 2026
Submission deadline	No file submission; competition is performance at events. Engineering portfolio/notebook submitted for judged awards
Total cost	The most expensive commitment on this page. Registration fees increase for 2026–27 . Figures surfaced: FTC ~\$525, FRC ~\$6,500 for season registration (covering one Regional for regional-model teams, or two District events). [U] LOW CONFIDENCE on both numbers — the FTC figure may be Canada-specific, and exact U.S. amounts sit behind a FIRST help-center article and the team dashboard. Add robot parts, tools, travel and often a second event. Sales tax now applies to some registrations that were previously untaxed. Team grants: https://www.firstinspires.org/programs/team-grant-opportunities
Format / artifact	Season-long design, build, program and iterate; judged Engineering Portfolio / notebook is the documented artifact alongside robot performance
Mentor policy	mentor-required — adult mentors are structural, and FIRST's culture explicitly centres professional mentorship. Strongest cultural fit of the robotics options
Award	Advancement to District/Regional/Championship; judged awards (Inspire, Think, Connect, Innovate, Control); substantial scholarship network — many university and corporate scholarships are open specifically to FIRST participants
Official URL	https://www.firstinspires.org/programs/ftc/ · https://www.firstinspires.org/programs/frc/ · Costs: https://www.firstinspires.org/programs/cost-and-registration
Confidence	Verified: age/grade bands, 2026–27 game names, FTC 12 Sep 2026 kickoff, the 17 Nov 2026 payment due date, the fact that fees rise and that sales tax newly applies, existence of team grants — from firstinspires.org / community.firstinspires.org . LOW CONFIDENCE: the \$525 and \$6,500 figures. Publish a "from roughly \$X, verify current pricing" range with a link, not a hard number

36. GENIUS Olympiad fee flag

Organizing body	Terra Science and Education, hosted at St. John Fisher University, Rochester, NY
Eligibility	Grades 8–12 , worldwide
Registration deadline	2027 applications open December 2026. Prior-cycle proxy: application deadline around 1 March , finalist participation registration around 1 May
Submission deadline	Project submission at the application deadline; finalists present in person in June
Total cost	[FLAG] \$50 application fee per project , plus — for finalists only — a participation fee reported in the \$425–\$850 range depending on accommodation (commonly cited as ~\$500 off-campus / ~\$850 on-campus), covering registration package, campus stay, dining, a Niagara Falls trip and airport transfers. Plus travel to Rochester. LOW CONFIDENCE on all fee figures — geniusolympiad.org 's own fee page did not surface; these come from the rules PDF mirror and third-party guides
Format / artifact	Environment-themed project competition across Science, Engineering, Art, Short Film, Music, Creative Writing, Robotics and Business — unusually broad, and the only entry here that takes humanities and arts projects on an environmental theme alongside science
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — adult advisers are standard; not verified as required
Award	Gold/Silver/Bronze medals by category; scholarship offers from partner universities
Official URL	https://geniusolympiad.org/ · Apply: https://apply.geniusolympiad.org/

Your call	Not a pay-for-certificate operation — projects are juried and rejected — but the finalist fee is high and lands on families only after their child succeeds , the same back-loaded pattern as Conrad. Additionally, the \$50-per-project application fee means every entrant pays something . Combined with our inability to verify the amounts on the organizer's own site, we'd hold this one pending a direct fee-page check
Confidence	Verified: grades 8–12, the eight categories, the Rochester/St. John Fisher venue, December 2026 application opening — from geniusolympiad.org . LOW CONFIDENCE: every fee figure and both prior-cycle deadlines

37. Lemelson-MIT InventTeams — ADDITION

Organizing body	Lemelson-MIT Program, MIT
Eligibility	High school teams — students together with a teacher and mentors
Registration deadline	Two-stage. The initial application is posted each October and due in early April for grants awarded for the following academic year
Submission deadline	Prior-cycle timeline (2025–26): initial application 23 April 2025 → finalist invitations 5 May 2025 → final applications 8 September 2025 → winners announced 26 September 2025 . 2026–27 cycle dates not confirmed as of 18 Sep 2026
Total cost	Free to apply — the award is money. No entry fee
Format / artifact	A year-long invention project : teams identify a real problem in their own community and build a technological solution, with MIT support throughout
Mentor policy	mentor-required — by definition. The funded unit is "students, teachers and mentors." Mentors are named in the grant structure, not merely tolerated
Award	Grants of up to \$7,500 per team , plus a year of structured support from the Lemelson-MIT Program
Official URL	https://lemelson.mit.edu/inventteams
Why we added it	It is the closest thing on this list to a funded version of what BlueRobins does: a mentor and a teacher and a team, funded for a year to build one thing. Very few competitions name the mentor as part of the award unit
Confidence	Verified: the up-to-\$7,500 grant, the students+teachers+mentors structure, the year-long build, the October-posted/April-due application rhythm, and the full 2025–26 date sequence — from lemelson.mit.edu . Not confirmed: whether the 2026–27 cycle is running on the same calendar. Check this one early — the April window is easy to miss a year in advance

38. World Food Prize Youth Institutes / Global Youth Institute — ADDITION

Organizing body	The World Food Prize Foundation
Eligibility	Grades 9–12 for most state institutes and the Virtual Youth Institutes; the Iowa Youth Institute accepts grades 8–12
Registration deadline	Set per state institute; paper submission and registration are usually a single deadline
Submission deadline	Varies by institute. Reference point: the Virtual Youth Institutes' paper and registration deadline was 20 May, 11:59 pm CT. 2027 dates not yet published
Total cost	Free. No registration cost, and meals are provided at the institute. Each high school in a participating state is guaranteed two Global Youth Institute spots
Format / artifact	A 3–5 page research paper on a chosen country and a food-security topic, written under the supervision of a teacher or mentor , then presented and defended at a state or virtual Youth Institute; top participants advance to the Global Youth Institute in Des Moines

Mentor policy	mentor-required — stated in the program description . The paper is written under teacher or mentor supervision
Award	Advancement to the Global Youth Institute; eligibility for the Borlaug-Ruan International Internship (an eight-week, all-expenses-paid international research internship at a partner research centre) and USDA/Wallace-Carver internships
Official URL	https://www.worldfoodprize.org/en/youth_programs/global_youth_institute/ · Paper resources: https://www.worldfoodprize.org/en/youth_programs/global_youth_institute/student_paper_resources/
Why we added it	Free, explicitly mentor-supervised, produces a real research paper, has published proceedings, and the top outcome is a paid international research placement rather than a certificate. It is arguably the best value-per-dollar entry in this entire document
Confidence	Verified: grade bands per institute, the 3–5 page mentor-supervised paper, zero cost with meals provided, the two-spots-per-school guarantee, and the Borlaug-Ruan internship pathway — from worldfoodprize.org . Not published yet: 2027 state and virtual institute deadlines, which vary by state

39. Modeling the Future Challenge — ADDITION

Organizing body	The Actuarial Foundation
Eligibility	U.S. high school students taking junior- or senior-level mathematics (statistics, probability, pre-calculus, calculus or similar). Submissions from one to five students
Registration deadline	Registration opens every Fall . The 2026–27 timeline was still marked tentative, to be finalised in late summer 2026 — check now
Submission deadline	Staged across the season; 2026–27 dates pending
Total cost	Free registration
Format / artifact	Students conduct their own research project : model real-world data, analyse risk, and make recommendations to a company, industry group, government or organisation. A full written research report, then finalist presentations
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — coaches and actuarial professional mentors participate; finalists meet actuarial professionals at the Symposium
Award	\$60,000 in scholarship prizes; finalists attend the Modeling the Future Symposium
Official URL	https://www.mtfchallenge.org/ · Timeline: https://www.mtfchallenge.org/timeline/
Why we added it	It fills a real gap: a free, genuinely research-shaped competition for the quantitative student who is not doing wet-lab science. Nothing else on this list serves the statistics/data-modelling mentee as directly
Confidence	Verified: eligibility and the math-coursework requirement, 1–5 student submissions, free registration, the \$60,000 scholarship pool, the research-report format, and that Fall registration is the pattern — from mtfchallenge.org . Not published at time of check: finalised 2026–27 dates (organizer said late summer 2026)

40. YoungArts National Arts Competition — ADDITION

Organizing body	National YoungArts Foundation
Eligibility	Artists in grades 10–12 or ages 15–18 as of 1 December 2026
Registration deadline	Same as submission
Submission deadline	[URGENT] 6 October 2026, 8:00 PM ET for the 2027 competition — under three weeks away

Total cost	An application fee is required, with fee-waiver documentation accepted . [!] The fee amount did not surface on youngarts.org — verify before publishing
Format / artifact	A discipline-specific portfolio : video recordings, audio recordings, documents or images depending on discipline. Juried by discipline panels
Mentor policy	mentor-permitted — teacher and private-instructor preparation is the norm in every discipline
Award	Two tiers. YoungArts Award: \$250 . YoungArts Award With Distinction : invitation to National YoungArts Week and eligibility for cash awards up to \$10,000 . Winners become eligible for lifelong YoungArts artist support; YoungArts is also the sole nominating body for the U.S. Presidential Scholars in the Arts
Official URL	https://youngarts.org/apply/ · Requirements: https://youngarts.org/apply/requirements/
Why we added it	The seed list had no serious 9–12 arts-portfolio entry beyond Scholastic. YoungArts is the most selective arts award available to this age group and is portfolio-based, which is exactly the multi-session artifact shape you're filtering for
Confidence	Verified : the 6 Oct 2026 8 PM ET deadline, the grades 10–12 / ages 15–18 as-of-1-Dec-2026 rule, portfolio submission requirements, the existence of an application fee and of fee waivers, and both award tiers with the \$250 and up-to-\$10,000 values — from youngarts.org . Not verified : the fee amount. Inferred : the Presidential Scholars nomination role — widely documented but not confirmed in this pass, so don't publish it without checking

CUT — NCF-Envirothon

Why cut	Fails the project-shape filter . The competition is built on field-station testing across five subject areas (aquatic ecology, forestry, soils and land use, wildlife, current environmental issue). There is a current-issue oral presentation , but the organizer's own rules state that " only materials identified by the Host and/or NCFE may be used by students during the training, testing, and/or the oral preparation and presentation portions of the competition " — the presentation is prepared on site, from supplied materials, inside the event. There is no durable student-authored artifact and no outside-mentor handoff
What it is, for the record	NCF-Envirothon; grades 9–12 / ages 14–19; teams of 5 ; United States, Canada and China; state and provincial qualifying, then an annual North American competition. A team substitution requires the state/provincial representative to certify an emergency at least two weeks before the competition
Official URL	https://envirothon.org/
Confidence	Verified from envirothon.org and its Rules and Regulations PDF. The cut is a judgment call against your filter, clearly reasoned above — overrule it if you value the environmental-science audience more than the artifact criterion , but the mentor handoff genuinely isn't there

Checked and confirmed defunct

Recorded so you know these were considered — both still appear on competition round-up blogs, which is precisely why the check was worth doing.

Program	Status
Google Science Fair	Defunct . Ran 2011–2018; last held 2018, not revived. Do not list
Siemens Competition in Math, Science & Technology	Defunct . The Siemens Foundation announced on 1 February 2018 that the 2017 competition was the final one. Administered by the College Board 1999–2013, then Discovery Education 2014–2017. Do not list

Checked, unresolved — do not list without further verification

Program	Problem
Rise (Schmidt Futures + Rhodes Trust)	A strong fit on paper: ages 15–17, project/video portfolio submission, and an award consisting of need-based scholarships, mentorship, career development and ongoing funding — close to ideal for this page. But: the most recent application cycle documented on <code>risefortheworld.org</code> itself is the 2023–24 cycle. No 2026 or 2026–27 cycle surfaced on the organizer's own site. Schmidt Futures has since reorganised. Treat as possibly dormant. Do not list until a current cycle is confirmed. https://www.risefortheworld.org/
NYT student contests	See entry #33. <code>nytimes.com</code> blocks our crawler entirely; all available lineup detail is aggregator-sourced and the official URL could not be confirmed

Cross-cutting notes worth acting on

1. The deadline cliff is now, not in spring. Five of the strongest entries close within ten weeks of this document's date:

Date	Program	Band
6 Oct 2026, 8 PM ET	YoungArts	9–12
26 Oct 2026, 12 PM ET	Congressional App Challenge	6–12
2 Nov 2026, 11:59 PM PT	NASA TechRise	6–12
5 Nov 2026, 8 PM ET	Regeneron Science Talent Search	12 only
1 Dec 2026 (first region)	Scholastic Art & Writing	7–12
13 Dec 2026	NFTE World Series of Innovation	5–24

If the page ships after these pass, it ships with six dead links to opportunities families can't act on. Consider a "closing soon" module, or publish the autumn deadlines first.

2. Registration and submission genuinely are months apart — your instinct was right. The widest gaps found: Congressional App Challenge (register from 1 May, submit 26 Oct), NASA TechRise (propose 2 Nov 2026, hardware due 19 May 2027), Invention Convention (affiliate registration in winter, Nationals in June), and the whole ISEF pathway, where the binding constraint is that **approval paperwork must be completed before research even begins** — many months ahead of any fair date.

3. Seven listed programs have no 2027 dates published yet. Technovation, Davidson Fellows, MIT THINK, Stockholm Junior Water Prize, 3M Young Scientist Challenge, Genes in Space and Zero Robotics' 2027 season. Build the page so a date cell can read "opens [month], date TBA" rather than silently carrying last year's date — that stale-date failure is exactly what makes aggregator round-ups untrustworthy, and it would be worse coming from us.

4. Mentor policy summary.

- **mentor-required (13):** ExploraVision · eCYBERMISSION · Future City · NASA TechRise · Genes in Space · The Junior Academy · MIT THINK · JFK Profile in Courage · Lemelson-MIT InvenTeams · World Food Prize · FIRST (FLL/FTC/FRC) · Conrad Challenge · 3M YSC (finalist stage)
- **mentor-permitted (all others listed):** every remaining entry
- **mentor-restricted:** none remain. The two confirmed conflicts, Odyssey of the Mind and Destination Imagination, were dropped at your instruction. Nothing on this list now carries an outside-assistance rule that a BlueRobins mentor would breach

5. The best structural fits for a mentor handoff, if you want a shortlist to build the page around: **MIT THINK** (the award is mentorship and funding for a project the student can't yet execute), **Lemelson-MIT InvenTeams** (mentors are named in the funded unit), **The Junior Academy** (every team is assigned a mentor), **JFK Profile in Courage** (a named adult must read and improve the draft), **World Food Prize** (paper written under mentor supervision, outcome is a paid research internship), and **Future City** (engineer mentor is standard, and the mentor's travel to Finals is funded).

What a human still needs to do before this page goes live

1. Open the URLs. They were confirmed as organizer domains, not click-tested.
2. Resolve the six **LOW CONFIDENCE** cells: FIRST fee amounts · GENIUS Olympiad fees · Concord Review fee · YoungArts application fee · AAHSFF standard entry fee · NASA TechRise dates on the organizer's own page.
3. Confirm NFTE: 12 or 13 December.
4. Confirm the JFK Profile in Courage submission deadline (source text was incomplete).
5. Visit the NYT Learning Network contest calendar directly and decide whether to list specific contests (entry 33).
6. Decide the four flagged fee/certificate cases: The Concord Review · GENIUS Olympiad · Blue Ocean · Conrad Challenge.
7. Re-check Zero Robotics in early October — its 2027 high school registration historically opens 1 October.